If you've picked this up because someone you love is autistic — or because you've started to wonder about yourself — welcome. There's nothing here that will make you feel got at.

In plain words

Autism is a different way of being wired, present from birth and lasting for life. It shapes how someone communicates, how they process the world through their senses, and how much predictability they need to feel alright. It isn't an illness, it isn't caused by parenting, and it isn't something that gets cured or grown out of.

What it can feel like from the inside

- Conversation takes deliberate effort that other people seem to get for free.
- Sounds, lights, textures and smells arrive at full volume, all at once, with no filter turning any of it down.
- Sudden changes to plans genuinely hurt, because the old plan had already been built in your head.
- A deep interest isn't a hobby — it's a place to go that reliably feels good.
- Being social is possible, and often wanted, but it costs energy that has to be paid back later.

What people often get wrong

THE ASSUMPTION	WHAT'S ACTUALLY GOING ON
"You don't look autistic."	There's no look. Many people, especially women and girls, have spent decades learning to hide it.
"Everyone's a bit autistic."	Everyone has a bad day with noise. Not everyone reorganises their whole life around it.
"They're in their own world."	Usually they're in this one, receiving far more of it than you are.
"They don't want friends."	Most do, very much. The usual routes to friendship are just exhausting.
"High or low functioning."	Support needs move about depending on the day, the place and the energy left.

What often comes with it

NOT COMPENSATION PRIZES — GENUINE, USEFUL THINGS

Noticing the detail everyone else walked past.

Deep, sustained knowledge of the things that matter to them.

Honesty you can rely on — you'll know where you stand.

Strong sense of fairness, and the nerve to say so.

Loyalty that doesn't need topping up with small talk.

What actually helps

- ☐ Say what you mean, plainly
- ☐ Send it in writing as well as saying it
- ☐ Ask before touching
- ☐ Give notice before plans change
- ☐ Let them leave early without a fuss
- ☐ Accept flat tone isn't rudeness

If someone tells you this is them

HELPFUL

“Thanks for telling me.”

“What would help?”

“I'll read up on it myself.”

LESS HELPFUL

“But you're so normal!”

“Have you tried a special diet?”

“We all get overwhelmed.”

Nothing here needs fixing. Understanding is the whole job.

A friendly explainer written for the community — not a diagnostic tool and not medical advice. If you want an assessment, your GP is the place to start. Nobody experiences this identically, so take what fits and leave the rest.

Free to share — print it, forward it, hand it to anyone who needs it. More free guides, one per neurotype, at froglogic.co.uk